Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Ametria Dock

Ametria Dock has fashioned an active career in the music world as a vocal soloist, coach and arranger. She frequently performs with Janelle Monae and India.Arie, and runs her own company, Fruition Organized Music.

Ametria was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 4, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Ametria Dock here with me today.

AD: Thank you for having me here. I'm glad to be here.

MR: Vocalist and coach and wearer of many hats as you said yesterday.

AD: Absolutely. A lot of hats, but all very enjoyable hats. I'm a vocal coach — well I'll start by saying I'm a wife, I'm a mother, I'm a vocal coach, I'm a singer, songwriter, vocal producer, so —

MR: It seems like in the music business these days, unless you're one of those people who've sort of risen way to the top, that you almost have to create your own niche. Is that a fair statement?

AD: Absolutely. Absolutely. I don't think I said this last night but you have to create a mission statement for yourself and that's something that I've done over and over again, to help myself to remember why I do what I do, and why I love the work that I do, and that's been something that has kept me motivated and excited about the work that I do. My goal is not to — the top for everyone I'm sure is different, so for me the top is being able to work with people and serve others and do this work just to create, and so that is a lot of things. That can be a lot of things for someone.

MR: You're almost addressing a question I was going to ask and so I'll go ahead — if you get a student that comes to you about the age of when you entered the business, which was around 18, 19, and they say, "I really want to make it in the music business." This idea of making it — do you address that?

AD: Absolutely. So I have a lot of young artists, up-and-coming I call them, artists, creatives. Now I have some that are really successful in movies and television right now that are transitioning over to doing more musical things. And we sit down and we talk about what is your idea of making it. What does that mean for you? What does that look like for you? Who does that look like for you? Who are some of the people that you think made it you know? Because sometimes what you think making it is not necessarily — I mean is it making a lot of money? Is it doing what you love everyday? You know what is it? So we sit down and we have conversations about that. And I have some really, really intelligent

kids that are way ahead of their time. So I'm blessed to be able to mentor and sit down and have real conversations about what that looks like. What does the next five years look like for you in terms of working on this music and working toward whatever goals you have. We sit down and we create plans and things like that. I think that's important — whether they're kids or college aged, 20, 21 years old and coming up with a plan of action.

MR: I wonder what the technology and the way music is delivered these days affects their vision?

AD: Yeah. 100%. I think it does. I think that social media, I mean it has its value, but it also makes the creative, the artist see something so fast. It's here today and it's gone tomorrow. And so music that artists that I loved growing up, you know, they had albums upon albums upon albums. And now we have singles. And they're here, they're here for a couple of weeks and then it's on to the next thing. And it's scary because you never really get to — I feel like a lot of artists got to really dig deep and develop and evolve and become. Artists today, that opportunity is, I mean you get a window and then you're gone.

MR: There used to be an art to creating an album concept, and which song should follow which and the keys and all that kind of thing.

AD: Yeah, yeah, yeah. There was a lot of thought put into making an album or creating a body of work, and then introducing it to the world you know. I think now there's more emphasis on introducing it to the world than the body of work, in my opinion.

MR: The initial event.

AD: Yeah. And it's interesting. It's like you're pushing to put something out instead of taking the time to really master and create, and so yeah that's my opinion.

MR: Okay. Let me ask you about your upbringing a little bit. Almost as an aside yesterday you had mentioned the Pentecostal church experience, and that you listened to secular music sort of on the sly?

AD: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about that.

AD: So my dad was the pastor, a Pentecostal pastor. And in our household the only thing that was an option was Gospel music. And so, and that was in my early years growing up. It was just — that Gospel music and my dad was a musician so we had a lot of live Gospel — and I've been saying this word all the time because it's the word that we say, it's just like vibe sessions, or worship sessions, where it was just live music and voices. And so that was a thing in my house, and my family, my grandparents' homes, my aunts and my uncles. My dad had ten brothers and sisters so we had a really big family. Everyone in the family was musically inclined. Everyone. My aunts played keys and guitar and my father

played the B3 and piano, and so I came from that kind of upbringing in the Pentecostal church. Gospel was what was central in our house.

MR: There's a lot of spontaneity in the presentation of that, right, every Sunday?

AD: Absolutely.

MR: So that concept of doing things on the fly was sort of built into you.

AD: Yeah. From early childhood like they had a guest speaker come in. My nickname is Mimi, and so my dad would say, "Mimi come on down." You know there was no prep. You know. So I've been making lists of my favorite songs since I was a kid. And that was helpful for me. I did it because I loved to do it, just to have, so I call it a "set list." I've been making set lists for myself since I was a kid, because I was always put on the spot. And you know, I'm sure anyone wants to just be prepared or ready and so I would practice not just because I wanted to be ready, but because I loved singing. But I was actually putting the work in to be prepared for whatever. It never failed anywhere I went, any church that we would go and visit I was always, always — I would be in the back of the church and they would call me to the front and I would have to sing a solo.

MR: Would you have to sing it in the key that they were going to play it in, or did you get to like suggest?

AD: So a lot of times, most times, some of the black church you have most of the musicians play by ear. So they're going to follow. So I would start.

MR: You would start the song.

AD: Oh yeah. I would start it and they would follow. And so, much like last night, and it just brought me back to my childhood, but yes, it would most of the time be like — or I would say I'm going to sing a particular song and if they knew me and knew the keys that I sang in they would put me in the keys.

MR: Okay. And the concept of then spinning off that song with some riffs and so forth, that was like natural.

AD: Yeah, yeah. And most times again, black church, black musicians, they are accustomed to that style of singing and so they know, you know, you're going to go off and they're going to follow you, they're going to follow where you go.

MR: I noticed last night when we did, we played "Summertime" and during those six, seven, eight beats after each line I was typically an accompanist goes okay I'm going to fill in there. But you filled in there, right?

AD: Yeah.

MR: I said, ah, okay, she's got this.

AD: I just, I love, and sometimes it just depends on when I'm singing and I'm kind of in the zone, when I hear different chords and different movements sometimes I like to sing over

them and sometimes I like to just let it breathe. But it felt really good last night so I just kind of went along with you guys.

MR: And I think it was nice for the students too, to hear that — taking a phrase and yeah I'm going to keep going with this within the context of the song.

AD: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

AD: It's fun.

MR: You have a daughter who's what, a teenager?

AD: Yeah she's 13, in seventh grade.

MR: Afterwards on the drive home last night I was thinking about when I was deciding about a career in music that my parents really didn't have any advice except get that teaching degree.

AD: Of course, of course.

MR: You have a bit more relevant advice for your daughter. What would you tell her about the music business at this point?

AD: So actually we've been talking about it. So my daughter is a straight A student. She is doing so well. And it's funny, she just did a talent show and won the all-school talent show this year, a couple of days ago. And I sat there and my mom and dad and my in-laws and our whole family was there to support her. And my mom was sitting and crying so hard. And she just looked over and she said, "This just reminds me of you all over again. I see what's happening." And she said, "But I see something different with Kayla." So my daughter is really — she loves science and she loves music. I mean her passion for music, I see myself in her. But she wants to create more — she wants to do more of the production, musical production. She wants to write music, she wants to create the music, she wants to engineer. So I see her going down a different path but I see her doing actually more than what I've done at this point. I see that happening. But I see her definitely going to school. I think, and I say this, I learned everything by ear, I got my start so young, and I wish I had — I did have community and accountability, but in a different way apart from school. So I had people that were doing this and doing well but see I want her to still be able to go to school and do this music and learn the technique and the theory. I think that that would be helpful for where she wants to go, what I see happening for her. So my husband and myself are both encouraging for her to go to school, because I know that she can go deeper within what it is that she is talking about now with us. And we're having really, really in-depth conversations about it now. But she's also got opportunities right now to do television. So we're in that.

MR: Wow. Lots of choices.

AD: Yeah.

MR: Which is wonderful and it also makes things a little harder.

AD: It does. I mean we're talking a seventh grader right now so we're not even in high school but she's getting lots of opportunities so far. It's funny her birthday is the same day as Janelle Monae and so Janelle always, she's like Aunt Janelle, so she's always talking to her and encouraging her, and motivating her, but she has the same, Janelle is doing movies and she's doing albums and touring and everything. And Janelle says I see myself in Kayla. It's the same. So it's so funny. Another story, I have another young 14-year-old who was on Broadway. I started with him he was 7 years old. And he got the part of Simba on Broadway. And so I started with him back then, he's now 14, he played Ralph Tresvant in the bio-pick of "New Edition," the television series that came out, and he's also played in several different movies with major actors and actresses. And he's doing the movies, and he has the same birthday as Janelle and my daughter. And it's so funny, they've collabed and we've done, I talked about last night doing "Singers Meet Singers" and I was talking about it in Doc's class today and this is my little group where I have all my singers. That's how I met Janelle. And so we kind of just started a new one for the kids, because I have a lot of kids that are in entertainment that want to be able to get together and vibe. And so my daughter is a part of that right now. So they're doing writing sessions, they're doing open mic sessions, because we don't have that available to kids. And so more like live shows and less like karaoke, so that they get the feel of performing and get the nerves and have a live band. And so I'm trying to create a creative space for kids to be able to explore and not live in their heads you know, about this entertainment and this music.

MR: Much like the word "fruition," that you've used for your business.

AD: Yeah, yeah, yeah. That was the whole point of it all.

MR: Did you feel, in retrospect, naïve about the business when you got into it?

AD: Yeah. Just the unknown, like I don't know what to expect, not knowing how to — there are lots of things: management and the people around at the time that were kind of controlling my career, making the — I'll tell you a statement that was made to me, that I had to do a lot of spiritual work to heal from, but I was told, "You worry about the singing, we'll worry about the business." And that was rough. At the time, as a kid, I was a kid, just turned 18 and signing a major deal with Universal. But that was the worst advice ever. But also at the time for me as a kid it was like okay I don't have to worry about that, I'm going to be taken care of, taken care of at that time. But it wasn't the case.

MR: Did you sign papers that you really didn't know what it said?

AD: No, — yes and no. I had an entertainment lawyer who was so awesome. And I remember the day that I signed my deal. My mother and my lawyer and my father, we were all sitting there. And my lawyer made the statement, she said, "You don't have to do this but

I can't tell you what to do, but you don't have to sign this deal." And so we walked through that deal, and we walked through — I signed a production — a production deal with a company that was also signing with the major label. And that deal was not good for me. But at the time I couldn't — I didn't know all the details of what that meant for me and what that meant for them. So they got the better end of the deal. I didn't.

MR: I see. And how long did it last?

AD: Four years. Yeah.

MR: Under the category of "live and learn" I guess.

AD: Absolutely. Absolutely.

MR: Well I'm just going to pause for someone at the door. Hold on one second.

MR: Okay let's talk a little bit about singing behind people and with people. I was able to have a conversation with Catherine Russell a couple of months ago and she talked about how being a back-up singer is not for everybody. What are the requirements?

AD: For the background singer?

MR: Yeah.

AD: Again being a background singer, you're serving the artist. And you have to pay close attention to the way that they do what they do — the movements, the texture, the tone, matching it, understanding what they want. So a lot of the artists that I work with, but specifically to date, specifically India.Arie, our tones are alike. And so our texture and our tone and our movements are pretty much the same. So I can match her. We just did an interview the other day, we did a Sirius Radio interview. And we did a live in-studio singing session. And the interviewer stopped for a second and said, "You guys sound like one voice." And a lot of times you need to be able to match your vocalist. So sometimes she may stop singing and I'll keep singing and I'll cover her in places where she needs to be covered. And so matching her tone and being able to smoothly harmonize is definitely a requirement for whatever artist you're singing with. Being able to know when you need to pull back a little bit, knowing when they want you to come forward. She is an artist that wants me more in the front than being in the back. Sometimes she wants me right next to her. And so for years, I've sang with her for 16 years. So touring, I know her tics, I know how she moves, I know when to add something, when, you know, she wants the color. You know some artists don't want the color so you have to know your artist, know what they're looking for, because the requirements are different from artist to artist.

MR: And from live to studio.

AD: Um hum.

MR: Do you normally — if you're doing harmonies in the studio, is the lead singer there?

AD: So most times yes. So we've done sessions where we do it together where we actually record, we're mic'd, we're all together and we do it. So that project that we did for — the

Israeli Project, we recorded live together actually with the band in the studio as well. And so that was an experience that was magical. But a lot of times we'll do individual stacks and so each singer will stack four times or three times, or you know, just depending on how big they want the sound, so yeah.

MR: You said something that reminded me of Joe Williams, who I explained had a big role in what we're doing here. You said, "Sometimes she wants me to pull back." And we filmed him once in a concert in our hall here, and there's this moment there where he was singing a ballad and the Count Basie Band is behind him. And he took the microphone, and the microphone was at belt level, right? And he was singing but he was using that microphone to his good effect. And then I thought about a lot of singers nowadays, I see them with these little mics that come down on their cheek. What's your feeling about those things?

AD: I hate those microphones. I hate those microphones and I hate in-ears. I love being able to connect with your audience. The microphones that are here are restricting, honestly. And most of the time when they have those type of mics it's because they're doing dance routines and things like that and so they have those mics to not be restricted in that way. But it's still, again, the emphasis is more on the performance and less on vocally what you're doing. And so sometimes you have the stems playing in the background so you don't have to work as hard as a singer. So they'll have the actual vocal playing and they're dancing, and their focus is more on the performance and less on you singing.

MR: It seems to be you're putting more emphasis on the sound person. You know what I'm trying to say? You can't sing full out but go back from the mic.

AD: Right, right. Go back from the mic. But here you don't have that option so they have to run something through the system because you're technically not singing really.

MR: Speaking of not singing, have you ever had to lip sync?

AD: No. Never. No. I don't think I would ever get a job like that. No I've never had to do that. Most of the artists that I sing are real live singers that I work with so yeah, no.

MR: Have you ever experienced any real train wrecks in live performance?

AD: For myself or for the clients that I've had?

MR: For yourself.

AD: For myself? I mean there's some times when the performance is not that great. And most of the time it's some type of emotional — something happening, where it's personal things happening, and my head wasn't fully in the game, but not often, and probably maybe one or two times in my career has that happened.

MR: You mentioned last night that the music business now has changed a lot from when you entered it, which isn't all that long a period.

AD: Yeah. I mean when I recorded my album we still had tape, so we hadn't switched over. We were just switching over to the digital everything. So I was at the tail end of that. But the music business and how things work — I remember having some conversations with some executives about how things were getting ready to change and become this digital thing. And we were moving into the singles world. And how the 360 deals and how record deals and how record labels were going to kind of fold and you know you, not having — I was given the opportunity to have artist development so when I talk about mentorship I had weeks of different mentors coming in to do artist development with me. You don't have that. Labels are not paying for artists to be developed anymore. So I worked with vocal coaches, I got a chance to really work on performance, and you know, an actual, we have, and I'm sure here, we have a lot of rehearsal spaces where there's mirrors much like a dance studio but it's actual — all the equipment and things you need for an actual show and so you're already put in that situation before going out on the road. And so those things were very key for me so going out on the road it wouldn't be foreign. Again, we don't have a lot of that here anymore. So even in my work with my company I'm really trying to create spaces and opportunities for people to get — if getting in this business is what you want to do these are some of the things that you've got to get prepped for. Because this is — you know being able to rent out Crossover Studios as a space, and working on that.

MR: The whole logistics of traveling is something you have to learn about too, right?

AD: Yeah, yeah, yeah. And so knowing, I mean my first touring experience I was given the opportunity the night before and the next day I was on tour for three months. So I talk about that a lot because I mean one day I'm working at the Hard Rock Café and the next day I'm on tour.

MR: I just have this image of you packing.

AD: At two o'clock in the morning. I don't know — I mean my roommate at the time, I just remember jumping on my bed with my roommate up and down saying I don't know what I'm doing. How is this — what am I going to do.

MR: That's great. Speaking of the digital world, if someone like a rap artist or a rap producer sampled you and used you in a production, do you think you'd find out about it the way things work these days?

AD: Sampled me, a vocal, like a riff or a run or something. Would I find out about it? Probably yes. And I'd find out if it went viral. And so that's the thing about today, everything goes viral fast if it's something that people like. And so yes, I think I would find out about it, and social media, I mean it would hit YouTube and Instagram, FaceBook, so fast that you know, I would know.

MR: You can't hide these days.

AD: No you can't.

MR: But this, I think it's a good thing being taken advantage of in that way.

AD: Sure.

MR: Do singers have the responsibility regarding accompanists to make it more likely that they're going to have a good experience. What is the singer's responsibility?

AD: Okay let me see what you mean.

MR: Well let's say you get invited to come up and sing. What would you want one of your students — how would they prepare for that?

AD: Okay. How would they prepare to come up and sing —

MR: In a club.

AD: Okay. So a lot I work on that for my clients. And so what we do is we sit down and we choose a set list for the types of songs. So there's a lot of work that goes in. We have to think about where you're going to perform, where you want to perform, so the types of clubs that you're performing at. We have an Open Mic club that is more singer/ songwriter feel and so it's more guitar and piano driven and so the types of songs that they sing at this particular club is more singer/songwriter as opposed to another club in the city that's more like pop and R&B and soul. And so it's about knowing where you fit, knowing — I wouldn't take one of my soul songs and go to Eddie's Attic in Atlanta, because it wouldn't fit there. But I could go to Eddie's Attic and I could sing a — who's my favorite — a Joni Mitchell song. It would go over well there. So we pick a set list, we work on the songs, we choose instrumentals or if you have an accompanist that can come and we can work through the song, we work through the song and get them prepared. Most times if you're doing live performances you want to make sure that you are rehearsing with the band and/or whomever will be playing with you.

MR: Do your students learn about the etiquette of relating to accompanist or a band, like I've sung now you do a gesture to the piano player, you got it, that kind of thing, when to come back in on the bridge.

AD: Yeah. So it varies from musician to musician. So there are some that are you know like I think it's really cool when some of the artists that are well known that I work with, that they take a moment to allow the band, the musician, the pianist or guitar player a moment of soloing so when it's that type of show you see more of that. When it's a one-off where they're just doing one song, most of the time you don't see the singer giving the band member solos, unless at a club event, you know what I'm saying? Like if it's an open mic. If it's an open mic kind of show the singer is the focus. If it's an actual show then everyone is the focus if that makes sense. In the culture in what I see, I see that happening a little bit more where the singer will kind of back off a little bit and then the pianist or the guitar player kind of just goes a little. So yeah.

MR: Have you ever had the awkward situation where someone comes to you and maybe you get the feeling they're coming to you because mom wants them to really. And the young person doesn't have, is not blessed with a voice.

AD: Yeah.

MR: What do you do?

AD: So most times, for me, when I get a parent that has a child that they feel like they've got something, we do an assessment. And so with my kids I generally don't like for the parents to be in the room because there is so much anxiety when the parent is there. They're not free to flow. So initially though I let the parents stay in because sometimes I've never heard what the child sounds like prior to them coming to me. And so I have the little things that I do just like, so improv exercises as well as checking if they can match pitch and that's a huge one, because if you have a child that you feel like they have the emotion but they can't match pitch that's a huge problem. And most of the time the parent is not a singer so the parent is like just like over the moon with the way that they emote but they don't understand that we're not singing in tune.

MR: Right. "What do you mean she can't match pitches?"

AD: Right. "I don't understand that." So I break it down and we talk about it and we have hard conversations sometimes. Because I feel like I'm a mom and I want someone to tell me the truth if my daughter was — my daughter is in track right now and it's so funny because she's not really fast. And we laugh because she's like, "Well it's good exercise, Mom." And so like if the coach — my husband is more of a sports — he played college ball and he's that guy and so he's like, "No, you can do this." And I'm like — and she and I are both — she's such a creative like, "I'm just doing it because I know Dad wants me to do some type of sports." But the coach is going to give us some feedback and was giving us feedback. And I want whoever's coaching to be honest you know. Maybe she'll be better. So yeah, I want to give the same to my clients.

MR: Well I know you have a busy day and I appreciate you taking — there's one just anecdote to share. Yesterday you were talking about early on you got in a position where the producer or whatever said, "So sing." Right?

AD: Yeah.

MR: And I'm thinking to myself what did she sing? And I play on occasion at homes for retired adults or so forth or nursing homes on occasion. And one song I always play is "You Are My Sunshine." And I'll be darned if that wasn't the song. I said I never would have thought of that.

AD: Wow. I use that all the time. It's like one of my faves. You know I love the way that that song just brings joy and makes me feel happy. It's a cute song, it's a happy song, but — and I know any time you hear that song it just makes you feel good, right? But sometimes

when I have a very advanced singer who's wanting to learn a different way to approach the way that they do what they do, I use "You Are My Sunshine" and I make it a little more complicated. And it's like, it feels light and bright, so I may make it feel more Gospel or make it feel more jazz, or make it feel more pop. So I just use that because it's such a happy song to me but you can do so many things with it.

MR: Yesterday you asked three times in a row I think, to these students after they sang, you said, "Do you listen to jazz?" Right? And so why?

AD: Because jazz to me, the way that jazz music feels, jazz to me is so big and so wide like when I think of it the movement in jazz is electrifying when I hear it, and it soothes but it also, it just gives so many different emotions, the way that jazz music makes you feel. So I feel like if you're a singer and you don't listen to jazz I think that's kind of like foundational. Like jazz, Gospel, blues, if you're just a pop — like where do — that's the start, just bottom line.

MR: Okay. Well here we are in our jazz archive and I think that's a good note to end on.

AD: Thank you so much for having me.